Panchen Lama, who independently controlled two major districts, offered to mediate, leading to the signing of a pact between the Bhutanese and the British in 1774.

At that time the British were trying very hard to open the Chinese coast for trading, but were being stalled by the Qing emperor who distrusted the western power. Hastings saw the Panchen Lama's intervention in the Bhutanese-Cooch Behar conflict as an opportunity to sponsor trade through Tibet. Accordingly, two British officials made their way to Lhasa where they were firmly told that whole of Tibet was subject to the Qing emperor, and China was unwilling to permit trade. All contact, they were told, had to be through Peking. This would have a deep impact on the British mindset, who would even in later years, continue to harp on Chinese suzerainty even when the Tibetans declared themselves independent in 1912.

The second incident was in 1788 when the Gorkhas, flush with their victory over Nepal and attracted by the monastic wealth of Tibetan monasteries, invaded from the south. In no position to challenge the Gorkhas, the Tibetans sued for peace and promised to pay annual tribute. This was agreed upon, but the tribute stopped after a couple of years, leading to the Second Gorkha invasion in 1791. In desperation, the Dalai Lama once again turned to the Qing emperor who was quick to dispatch a 10,000-strong army to Tibet's aid. The Chinese army not only stopped the Gorkhas, but pushed them right back into Nepal, getting to within thirty-odd kilometres of Kathmandu. The Gorkhas now sued for peace, offering to pay Peking a tribute every five years. The Gorkhas lost the war, and in the process they also succeeded in bringing China into direct contact with the Indian subcontinent for the first time ever.

TIBET'S RELATIONSHIP WITH INDIA

Tibetan links with the Chinese until the 1700s were almost non-existent, but they had an intricate relationship with Indian states with a great degree of trade and religious exchange. Though there had been conflicts and invasions, the topography, with its naturally defined borders, ensured that there was very little friction between the Tibetans and the various Indian states. Apart from Kashmir in the west, the Sikhs, the Nepalese, the Lepchas, the Bhutanese and the various tribes living in the jungles of NEFA, all had common borders with Tibet. In the east, most of the NEFA tribes—the Aka, the Daflas (now known as Nyishi), the Adi and the Mishmi